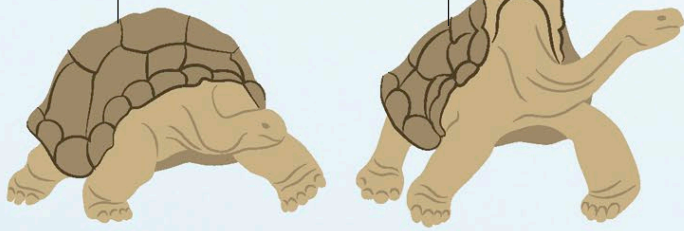


Domed shell

Saddleback shell



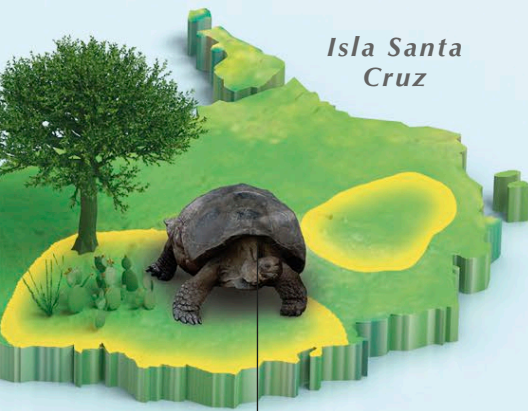
Shell shape and diet

On wetter islands with plenty of ground plants to graze, the shells of Galápagos giant tortoises are dome-shaped. But on drier islands, tortoises have evolved raised shells – called saddlebacks – and long necks. This helps them reach tall cactuses that grow higher from the ground.



Lonesome George

In 1971, scientists found the only surviving Pinta Island giant tortoise. The rest of its kind had died out, due to the overgrazing by goats introduced to the island. Named Lonesome George, this tortoise became a symbol of conservation, living out his life in captivity. He died in 2012.

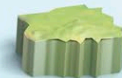


Isla Santa Cruz

Santa Cruz giant tortoise

The dome-shelled giant tortoises of Santa Cruz live in separate populations on this island, and studies suggest that they might be different species.

Isla Santa Fe



Island giants

The Galápagos Islands erupted from the ocean more than three million years ago.

Tortoises landed on their shores after floating across the waters from South America. With no natural predators, they evolved into giants and, as they adapted to the different conditions and food sources on each island, into separate species. Seven of these are shown on this map.

San Cristóbal giant tortoise

Animals introduced to this island, such as dogs and donkeys, drove San Cristóbal tortoises almost to extinction, but better control measures and captive breeding are helping to save the species.



Española giant tortoise

On one of the oldest and most barren of the Galápagos Islands, Española tortoises have especially high-saddled shells to help them reach up to nibble on the scarce food growing here, such as cactuses.



Isla Española

Galápagos Islands



Isla Santa Maria

Galápagos giant tortoises

Tortoises are slow-moving reptiles with a heavy, protective shell. Some of the biggest tortoises on Earth live on the rugged, volcanic Galápagos Islands far out in the Pacific Ocean. Each island is home to its own species.

